The God File

By Frank Turner Hollon

GABRIEL: **(Pg 138)** *(praying)* "Now I lay me down to sleep, I pray the Lord my soul to keep. If I should die before I wake, I pray the Lord my soul to take."

(Pgs 6-13) *(to audience)* So you say you believe in God? So you say that you see evidence that God exists, and not only does he exist, that he cares about you? *(bitterly)* Spend almost 22 years in a maximum-security Alabama penitentiary for a murder you didn't commit and then tell me God exists.

I was here 3 months before my mind would let me read, then I started reading anything with words. Anything. I read a book about a man with cancer. He was a doctor with a supportive wife and blue-eyed kids. His cancer was cured [and] he wrote about his proof of the existence of God and signs that the Lord had cured his cancer. It must be pretty easy to see signs of God's existence when you're a rich doctor with a wonderful wife and children, cured of cancer and writing stories about pretty visions.

[But] it would really be a test to find this evidence in a nasty place like this, with no real freedoms, surrounded everyday with fear, hopelessness, and people who live like rats. So, I started a file. The God file. A cardboard box filled with envelopes and notes. The file has gotten fat. A brown box kept underneath my bed. I've believed and disbelieved a thousand times.

INTRODUCTION

What if everything you believed about God fell apart in a single moment? When Gabriel Black's life collapses into a prison cell, fear and silence fills his mind and belief in God is less than comforting. So, Gabriel starts keeping track, collecting his thoughts and memories in a box he calls "The God File." There must be some proof of God even in the brokenness of his life.

When everything is taken from you, is faith something you lose, or something you fight for?

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GABRIEL: (Pg 6-13) My name is Gabriel Black. I was 25 years old when I first saw Janie. She was married and didn't care. I had no direction; no purpose. She became my purpose. A living, breathing, everyday reason. I knew the moment I met her something bad would happen. I knew the whole thing was wrong when I decided to be with her. And the price I paid came a thousand decisions later, in an apartment on a Saturday morning.

Janie's husband had called the day before. I imagined his fat-wheeled Ford truck driving past the apartment. He was bigger than me, unpredictable and pissed off. I imagine every night that he slept alone was a reminder of what he'd lost – Janie. *(beat)* Since the dawn of time men have been killing each other over *women.* We will kill each other faster of *women* than anything else, including food, shelter, even religion.

I was sitting on the couch at 8:30 on Saturday morning when the front door busted open. Janie's husband's shoulder hit the wood and the doorframe splintered. Janie came out of the bedroom, with a gun in her hand. There was no time to speak. Before my gaze lifted, she fired twice into his chest. I saw the holes explode open. Her husband fell to his knees, and his face cracked against the glass of the coffee table, which shattered into a million specks of light. And then it was quiet.

I will never understand the reasons I did what I did next. Love? Honor? Loyalty? *(beat)* I took the gun from her hand, wiped it clean, and holding it in my right hand, I fired once at the far wall to get the smell on my hands.

I looked at Janie, and said, "I killed him. You were in the bedroom sleeping; you heard the shots and came out. Wash your hands, someone will be here any second." [She] didn't hesitate. Turns out the gun was stolen. The apartment? In the dead man's name. She met with him the day before. Could she have planned it? Known I would take the blame? She's never come to visit me, ever. The only time I saw her again was in the courtroom 22 years ago. She sat stone-faced with the angry relatives of her dead husband.

Guilty. Capital murder. Life in prison without parole. *(beat)* Does God exist? I set out to look for God in the tiny details, to find out for myself. All I have is time . . . So, I put together a file, to look for God in the tiniest details. *(shuffles through his box and selects a file folder)*

THE FEAR FILE: (Pg 28-31) *(he reads)* The two most traumatic events in our lives are birth and death. The fear of each is a gift. Fear lets us know when we are in danger. It can't be separated from our survival instinct. *(stops reading to tell his story)* [But] once you start removing the fear, how do you know when to stop? The world is divided into warriors and non-warriors.

(Pg 39-43) The first time I was raped in this place, I thought about my daddy. I'd only been here a week – had no idea what it takes to survive. I was small and walked with a limp. I was selected for my weakness, like animals separate the herd. It ain't got *nothin'* to do with pretty. There were three of them. I fought like a dog, bit and scratched, felt the punch shatter my ribs and suck the breath from my lungs. They thought it was funny.

When it happened the second time, I was ready. I fought until they thought I was done fighting, and then I cut the man with a piece of a razor. It was the last time they tried. The risk and the reward were no longer equal. You should have seen his face that split second from the time he saw what I had done until the pain shot up his backbone. *(beat)* Sometimes God hides Himself in the cracks between words. **(Pg 65)** They say that God never puts more on you than you can carry. When He does, when He goes too far, how will I know? *(selects another file from the box)*

THE CANCER FILE: (Pg 32-36) My mother died of breast cancer when I was 19. I came home from the Army on emergency leave. She had given me no warning. Maybe she had none. The doctor said, "The cancer is eating her up inside," like he was angry. Like he couldn't understand any more than I could why God would let evil black cells chew up my mother's breast from the inside out and leave her choking up blood on the white sheets of someone else's bed. They put crosses on the sides of highways where people die in car wrecks. Nobody put a cross in the hospital bed where cancer killed my momma. *(long beat)* Are we

so afraid of cancer that we let it take who it wishes, as long as it leaves the rest of us alone. Abandoned by God for letting it do what it wants? *(beat)* [At least] Momma never had to see me in shackles. She never had to sit in the courtroom, torn between the love of her child and hatred. She never had to see me go to prison, or lie awake at night and wonder what unspeakable thing was happening to her boy in a prison shower.

(Pg 123) *(long beat)* I used to believe that the proof of God in suicide was my decision to choose AGAINST it every day. I know that the ***option*** is the gift. We don't condemn the man in physical pain, with incurable cancer, when he takes his own life. But there's pain in this world worse than any physical pain that might wrack this body of mine. God gave us a soul [and] with the soul comes the capacity to hurt worse than any animal or beast. Not only can we feel this pain, but we can understand it and put it in words. *(struggles to contain the pain he feels)* I have asked myself the question a million times, "If God gives me more than I can endure, how will I know?" He'll bring me home, that's how I will know. *(beat; he begins to fashion a noose from his bed sheets and continues this process as he speaks)*

(Pg 73-74) People seem to turn towards God when they have lost control of their lives. There is no place in the world like prison to make a person feel lost. I have watched men sit in their cells and read the Bible all day long. Every day I am told where I will sleep, when I will eat. My mail is opened, my room is searched. Others decide my choices of books, clothes, toilet paper, food. [But] I have tried hard not to make my decisions about God from a position of fear or loneliness or loss of control.

(Pg 107-109) I have read books of theology and the history of religion. But the real evidence of the existence of God is my existence itself – the existence of a human being. They write that the definition of a Christian is the belief in Adam and Eve, and the definition of a nonbeliever is the person who has allowed the science of Darwinsim to rot his soul. It isn't that easy. Or maybe it isn't that complicated. *(thoughtful)* If I were God, I would use time to create my most wonderful creation, a person. God is in no hurry. The Earth, the oceans and other animals and plants existed before we did. The battleground of evolution and Adam and

Eve? Same God, same idea, same tool. Only God could use time and only time could make a person, any person.

(Pg 152-154) In my years of keeping the God file, I have come to believe that the greatest evidence I have of God's existence is not me, but is the search itself. I have to believe that God sent me on this search, and the search itself has nourished and sustained me. It's the most obvious gift from God, and it has been in front of me every single day.

We're taught to believe that there is a hierarchy in the closeness of God. *(places the noose over his head)* But at this moment, this exact moment, no one could be closer to God than I am. I can close my eyes and feel His arm around me, tight and sure, like I was a little boy again. *(long beat as he breathes in an out deeply)* **(Pg 129-130)** We forget the stillness of silence. I search my memory for the sounds in my life that stand apart and can still make me feel the way I felt when I heard them for the first time: My mother crying *(voice cracking with emotion)* . . . **(Pg 138)** "Now I lay me down to sleep, I pray the Lord my soul to keep. If I should die before I wake, I pray the Lord my soul to take." **(Pg 129-130)** The sound of my mother crying made me feel more worthless and alone than any sound in my life. I wish I could hear it one more time to know she was in the room next to me.

(he startles) The sharp sound of Janie's gun firing the first bullet. *(beat)* The sound of the prison door closing behind [me] The heavy, iron vibration. This sound would be one I would always remember.

(Pg 156-157) *(tightening the noose; he speaks as he loses consciousness)* And I begin to move. Gently toward the soft, white light. Pulled by the strings of faith. And suddenly there is a sense of leaving something behind . . . **(Pg 138)** "I pray the Lord my soul to take."

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AWARD HISTORY

2003 National Qualifier
2005 National Qualifier
2010 National Qualifier
2016 National Qualifier - MS
2019 National Qualifier
CA State Qualifier

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